Marxist could manage to get the important portfolios. This helped them to improve their position in the mid-term poll in Bengal raising their strength from 43 to 60.'[116]

Finally, Mehta argued that generally 'all political parties and especially the Congress and the Communists make use of the Government Offices to propagate and popularise the principles of their respective parties. The Jan Sangh performance in this respect is totally poor. Jan Sangh therefore failed to consolidate its strength in the masses and met with reverses, whereas the Communist Party Marxist with portfolios like finance, labour could penetrate deep in the labour field and consolidate the party gains.'[117]

Mehta's booklet is fundamental to understanding the BJP's politics today. In the course of participating in electoral politics, the Jan Sangh was learning lessons that the BJP would later implement. Anyone looking to understand the BJP's focus on ideological penetration, realpolitik, cadre mobilisation and its take-no-prisoners approach under the Modi–Shah duo has only to look at this churn in the Jan Sangh in the 1960s.

Those early leaders looked to emulate the Left's growth strategies and learnt the following lessons from their own failures: do not depend too much on the middle classes, focus on the rural poor, do not be overly focused on intellectuals, build a cadre and leverage power well. Ironically, the communist parties have since withered away, while the BJP has adapted its tenets to great effect.

What Did the Jan Sangh Stand for?

In August 1966, Balraj Madhok, president of the Jan Sangh, delivered a seminal lecture at the Ahmedabad Junior Chamber: 'What Bharatiya Jana Sangh Stands For'. His speech, combined with another document the party published a year earlier, 'Bharatiya Jana Sangh: Principles and Policies', provided the most succinct summary of how the party saw itself and how it hoped to reshape India. Apart from its position on Kashmir, its anti-Congressism and its links with the RSS, the Jan Sangh's primary energies remained focused on responding to the question of communalism and the ordering of Hindu–Muslim relations.